

Real reports lead to officers facing real consequences

Decision 1 – Universe scoped to substantiated cases only

Score: -2

The visualization displays only the 8,301 allegations the CCRB substantiated, omitting the 25,057 that were unsubstantiated or exonerated. The subtitle reads "8,301 substantiated cases" without reference to the full dataset, so a reader has no basis to ask what fraction of all complaints this represents. Showing the full distribution would reduce the apparent scale of accountability considerably; only about 1 in 4 allegations reaches any outcome at all.

Decision 2 – Three command discipline tiers collapsed into one bar

Score: -1

The CCRB distinguishes between Command Discipline, Command Discipline A, and Command Discipline B. The differences in severity between these are not explained in public-facing documentation. Collapsing all three into a single "Command discipline" bar (2,604 cases total) reduces clutter and avoids confusion. It also produces a larger bar that sits more prominently in the chart. Keeping them separate would've yielded three mid-sized bars whose counts are less striking.

Decision 3 – "Formal charges" bolded and encoded in dark navy

Score: -0.5

Formal charges are given a bold label and a saturated dark navy, while all other outcomes share a lighter blue. Formal charges are the plurality outcome, but the two colors imply a greater distinction than the data necessarily supports. The legend reinforces this by grouping everything other than formal charges under a single label.

Decision 4 – Labels rewritten from original CCRB terminology

Score: -1

CCRB outcome labels such as "Substantiated (Command Lvl Instructions)" and "Substantiated (Instructions)" were shortened and reworded to "Supervisory instructions" and "Corrective instructions." The original phrasing includes qualifiers that the rewritten versions drop. Whether the new labels seem more or less severe than the originals is somewhat subjective, but they present the outcomes as more deliberate and consequential-sounding than the source terminology conveys.

Decision 5 – Title uses causal language

Score: -0.5

The title implies a reliable causal relationship between filing a complaint and an officer receiving a consequence. "Real" appears twice, which implicitly preempts a skeptical

reading. Since only 24.9% of all allegations are substantiated, the title's framing applies to a minority of complaints, which isn't visible anywhere in the chart.

3 in 4 NYPD misconduct allegations result in no officer accountability

Decision 1 · Full 33,358-allegation universe shown — no filtering

Score: +2

Unlike Concept A, this chart uses the complete dataset without any filtering by outcome. The subtitle explicitly states "All 33,358 allegations," and the proportional bar reflects the full distribution.

Decision 2 · Warm red tones used for unsubstantiated and exonerated outcomes

Score: -0.5

Unsubstantiated and exonerated outcomes are encoded in two shades of red. These are legally neutral findings, as an unsubstantiated complaint means the evidence was insufficient, not that misconduct did not occur, but these colors tend to read as negative or alarming in visualization conventions.

Decision 3 · "3 in 4" headline framing rather than "75.1%"

Score: -0.5

The title uses a ratio rather than a percentage. They're numerically equivalent, but ratio framing tends to feel more concrete and personal than a percentage, since it maps onto an implied individual experience rather than just a statistic.

Decision 4 · Substantiated outcomes split into "Other consequences" and "Formal charges"

Score: +1

Rather than grouping all 8,301 substantiated cases into one category, the chart separates formal charges (11.4%) from other substantiated outcomes (13.5%). Formal charges represent the most severe end of the CCRB's penalties, and it gives readers a more accurate picture of what "substantiated" means in practice. It also has the visual effect of reducing the apparent footprint of the blue segments relative to how they appear in Concept A.